"Remember… Consciousness is power. Tomorrow's world is yours to build."

—Yuri Kochiyama, 20th century civil rights activist, humanist

January 2nd, 2069, 4:01AM

"Donchu fuckin' dare!" Pace Tom shouted.

His leggy form vaulted over the hood of his stranded hovercraft, his effortless bedhead hair tossing briefly in the air. Even in anger, he smiled a little smile, admiring his own movement, his own finesse. Too cocky. His jeans snagged on the hood ornament, one he had jacked from a higher-end vehicle but never installed properly. His half-assed handiwork caught up to him. The denim ripped from hip to thigh. He went down hard. Pace posted a hand to soften the impact.

Crunch.

a little confusing - I had to read twice to understand this

It had been three hours to Vegas. And it had been three hours for five or six. Time ran on, same as the sands—dismal, microscopic, in pleats of spirals and wavelets that whispered "Almost, almost"—but to whom, and for why,

was each one's interpretation who floated along that old dusty highway and the airoad above.

Pace didn't ask. He had no capacity. His eyes were so heavy… laden by the insomnia of a ninety-six-hour binge, he barely hovered over the controls.

The purity of that gem of Hala he had doubted.

there is a switch to present tense here

And he didn't want to know lest his guilt bads the trip.

So, at that DNA lounge in Frisco, surrounded by a sea of neural cocktails, Pace had huffed it—huffed it with such desperate craving that, seeing him, even a shipwrecked sailor—dying of thirst—

Huffed it. Huffed

make the first one a comma. maybe no punct, where 2nd dash is, or consider comma too

Help me with punctuation (clarity) in this long sentence? The drinking salt water metaphor. Kept it intentionally long to mimic an addict's craving

consider adding even more convolution and clauses if this is the goal?
But maybe avoid dash construction as it gets hard to track what is referring back to what.
(the actual grammatical intention of dashes is to do this)

would have been chagrined
to drink
the water from the sea.

He sniffed.

A dribble of blood crawled out of his thinned nostrils. The aftertaste in the back of his throat was iron, nickel. Why is the Sun hiding.

italics?

I didn't get that he'd boarded a literal craft until the next page - see yellow

The message to pull up melted into the onboard symphony, which, on repeat in the way he liked it, became its own hypnotic nostrum. The horizon stayed flat, glowing promisingly with new burst, yet unarriving. The sands slipped by. Even the parallax of the mountains, the only change in scenery that had kept him perked,

try "that repeated"… "becoming" or HE

Now, cruising over the ___ desert at ___ feet,

"writerly"

a?

grammar: what is unarriving - the horzion, or the new burst?

somnambulated to a still sleep. Sands slipped by.

I like this

Mountain peaks stacked with augmented perspective lines into an Isoceles. He flew toward the tip of that triangle, laxing into the convergence of some infinity.

It was too late. here is where I get where it's not all in his mind/trip. Clarify this where I made the yellow highlight on previous page

The overlay in the hovercraft fizzed out as the vehicle dipped beneath the airoad's visual stream. The craft went down. Down. Down, until its belly slid onto the plush sand, red paint rinsed from its bottom to chrome, like some beluga bird-fish finally beached and at home. There

as noise..... add clause about stolen dampener

I like this

was the sound of snow in the desert: noise diffused

why the parentheses? also-stolen

through the cabin's (stolen) dampener. Pace had installed it himself, more than expertly, because he prided himself on a job well done when the job's got meaning—especially for an audiophile, extreme.

slips into present/"voicey-ness." What is character voice vs narrative voice, and when to deploy this mode?

italicize

So the craft went down gently, with Pace plastered over the yoke, right cheek embedding an imprint, tongue drooling. His bloodshot left eye remained open, though. From an unconscious depth, his fingers still tweaked the controls, smoothing out the landing.

good verb choice

Pace was taking a piss in the unobstructed open, unjacketed, shivering against the pre-dawn morning, when the towman came along the highway on wheels.

maybe flip these?
Start with "The towman…" or the "The towman had"

Don't open with a passive
Open with something sensory

It was a big truck. A rig, really. Sixteen wheels, mounted in sets of twos, supported the monstrous angularity of the vehicle, which with a cabin lurching over the front like a head and smokestacks like ears on top, gave it the look of a hound. The rig had not been built for municipal duty. Its fate had been for war. But the war never came. Burned in black stencil against its rusted hull was the company's name, which read:

vehicle. A cabin, or semicolon

good

preponderous is a madeup word; it sounds like preposterous, and is a combination of preponderant and ponderous

I'm fine with this

"Sentinel Tower, NLC."

Pace stared at the preponderous machine as it slowed, grinding and groaning under the impedance of its own weight, the brakes catching, skipping, screeching. He winced. Slowly, it pulled off the asphalt. Four times it stuttered. Ba-dum. Ba-dum. Ba-dum. Ba-dum. Once for each row of wheels. The tires, tall as a man and hard as stone, rolled over the dip and hump of the asphalt onto sand.

Pace squinted at the logo as the rig trawled toward him. His hairs stood up against the sloshing friss of million grains giving way.

of sand

adding "of sand" prioritizes reader-friendliness over writerliness.

"Sentinel Tower," he said.

Lmk if the joke is clear

…no… maybe it's the towman commenting on Pace's penis? But I wouldn't have caught this unless it was flagged as a joke. Maybe a gestural tag pre-dialogue from the towman here?

Pace shivered. Then went back to his business. Swaying his hips, he repeated the word. "Tower?" He played with the syllables, breaking them apart. "Tower. Tow-er." He

squeezed his bum, "oh tower," and expelled the last of the stream. "That doesn't look right," he mumbled, "that spelt right?" He zipped up, careful not to catch the goods.

elbows to trap

Arms tucked over opposite elbows, trapping in heat, Pace walked back. The Sun had yet to come up, still.

to where?

The blur of white over the horizon softened invitingly, spread osmotically through a void atmosphere as the day waits for day to come. In this moment, in the liminal dark, things felt possible. Light had not cast its certainty onto the world yet, judging harshly. Unlike midday, when the sun blared overhead—playing its heat too bright, baking the world solid, so the day felt ready to be done with—before morning, the atoms had not congealed yet. Clouds of possibility fanned and frayed high and thin, seeping with incandescence.

waited

I like this atmospheric para

A crisp wind blew. Pace sucked it in and choked on oxygen. He hacked, bowled over. His eyes stung with brine, and yet that little smile appeared, curling the corners of his mouth into a little wave like the Milky Way.

He looked at that horizon line so far away. He wished he had arrived.

He also wished it stayed forever far away, because in that awayness it was imperishable… angelic. He could not screw it up.

Pace sighed.

The sound of pneumatic stakes puncturing sand turned his head.

The rig had expanded into a platform. Mounting posts stapled into the ground. Its side was anchored toward the beached beluga, and an array of harpoons—primed with towline—was at the ready. Then it dawned on him.

Pace sprinted.

”Donchu fuckin’ dare!” he shouted…

…Crunch.

It's pretty clear that this is what happened right before he hopped over the hood?

we can talk about seeding a slight additional breadcrumb or two…
Making the backstory transition clearer on p.1, and maybe even showing him vault again here in 1/2 a sentence

The towman?

He was writhing on the ground. Pace grabbed his wrist and kicked his feet. The patter sounded plump on the fabric of the sands, while the hardpan beneath thumped, echoing like muted drums through the valley. Pace cursed. Gurgled. His fractured ulna shorted his nerves with white-hot pain. He bit his tongue. But too hard. Which drew more blood. Which, invited more cursing. He curled into a ball.

Let’s talk about these rhythms. I could go for short, but perhaps rethink the “because of this” frame of the sentence progression

The towman took one look at the ragged figure and shook his head, then went about his business with the guns.

“You gonna give me a hand?” Pace shouted.

No answer.

"You're not—"

Hands-free, he posted onto his shoulder, then shrimped and wormed onto his knees.

all verbs here are figurative. Change "posted" to something easier; then you can keep the other two

"You're not—"

who? his own?

Pace sank between his hips. He was heavy. His muscles clung to his bones. Once-soft colors turned lurid. A tinny pitch climbed in his ears.

The Hala was wearing off.

The sky melted. Stars became appalling. A guttural, primal mode of surviving replaced sentiments of grandiosity. The horizon—that reliable line—tilted. The ground untethered. What is a primate to do

when the line

it orients by

vanished beneath its feet?

ok, seeing now the shift to lineation is intentional.

Pace staggered and fell to his side. Colors drained. He shut his eyes. Cupped his ears. As pain took on sound.

maybe just Pain… ?

His Withdrawal Overture began. No.

Begun.

A hellish orchestra tuned to a cacophony. His head was vised. Too full. His skull flooded. Fluids pressed and crashed against his brain. Sound; pressure; agony—all were swelling. Even his scalp was too tender for his hair. When they stirred, fields lit aflame. Pace screamed. The

pandemonium racked so loud, he may as well have been screaming into eternity.

Strings. First Strings, Second Strings;
Scratched across his membrane.
Brass and Winds ballooned
gray matter near rupture.
Mater, he moaned, I'll be pious—please,
Save the rapture for me.
Poor boy.
It was hard to endure.
His blood strangled.
His breath chocked.
His mind primed to explode—
Then crash!
Cymbals—those blasted things—
Crash! Bang! Hassan!
His gut lurched up.
He fought it down.
Drums.
Drums shook from his temple
To his white core.
Beats. Beats. No…
Feet.
Struggling, Pace pried an eye open.

Thoughts on the asides:
It was hard to endure.
Poor boy. ?

I like that this is mentioned here

General thoughts on this?
The intention is for it to be almost too much as it is for the character but I wonder how it could be done better or what's not working. It's all in his head, and the body stuff is mixed in with his nausea

I think it's fine as is… but… my larger thought, which started previous page, is: "When are we going to get back to the external scene/the interaction w the towman?" Perhpas he can even "see' the towman in his peripheral vision, etc But we don;t want to lose all sense the towman is there

And saw—Hell's Conductor.

The demon lunged toward him, wielding a needle as a baton. Its point glinted with an evil star.

Back! Back! Cursed demon, back!

You—djinn of ruin! I like the assonance here

Pace kicked his feet to run, but they flopped. He gasped, his lungs failed. Shadow loomed over him. The demon reeked of gasoline. Behind, its colossal hound—Cerberus—blew acrid smoke through its upturned nose. The sludge of billion years vaporized into smog. The smell dragged Pace back to that DNA lounge, back to a fecal-stained stall where, near mad, copulating, he had smelled the mixture of tar and human waste. There, Pace had prayed to God. *Take me home*. No one answered.

No, Pace protested, eyes widening. He wasn't really ready to go. to go where? Home? add just a brief word or three. No more.

The towering demon raised the needle.

No.

It drove the point down. Into Pace's heart. What little space remained in his psyche swelled with music.

Then all stopped.

Pace was dead.

He opened his eyes to the quiet. How strange it is to hear the harmony of an absolute hush. How wonderful, was

the sound of no sounds.

A puff.

His

His chest released. Pressure escaped. Airway opened up. Pace gasped! An animating spirit surged through his body.

ambivalent about this

How's the sequence and order of operation of the death + revivial scene?

His heart beat again.

The syringe had delivered its antidote.

His head hit the ground. His esophagus opened as he pushed the poison out. His sins came up in liquids and chunks. It felt so cathartic. So good. He was no more human than a meat tube expelling its innards.

good

Yet somehow, even in this undignified state, an old joke still came up. Marcos said: "What did the monk say to the hotdog vendor?"

When do we italicize again?

Make me one with everything.

yes, this is the right move here.
To emphasize internal thoughts or dialogue, or the recollection of dialogue from others

Pace heaved.

technically, this should be a semicolon — which I think is a useful tool to add to your punctuation bank, as it allows for additional variety in sentence structure

Everything out.

The world calmed. Ground settled below, sky returned above. The horizon separated apes from angels once again.

good!

Pace, prostrated on the ground in a puddle of his own orange and brown, enjoyed the serenity. Little tremors worked themselves out. The day's first beams even washed his face.

I like that the agency is given to the tremors - they are the subject here (vs Pace)

The shadow stepped back.

Pace squinted at the large man.

"You alive?" the towman asked.

Pace grinned stupidly from cheek to cheek. Hoarse with acid, he said:

maybe confusing bc acid/Hala …. "bile?"

Y

"You're not—you're not towing my car."

car?

The towman's mouth opened.

Then closed.

"Jesus Christ," he whispered, and put the syringe back into his pocket.

We change POV to the towman because
1) reader is probably exhausted, I know I am
2) Pace is blacked out and not interesting rn
3) see him from external and 4) world build through another character. Thoughts?

The towman, whose name was Henry John, lugged Pace over a shoulder. The long one's weight swung unevenly like a sack of logs.

show this, earlier. Nametag?

since you are an omniscient 3rd-person narrator, you can shift like this. So you're not technically changing POV. But the space break is a good way to help signal your "camera" has gone somewhere else.

noun - "his cargo" etc

Henry humped it to the passenger side of the rig and whistled for the lift. The rig listened, clunking into action, lowering a cantilevered scaffold as an ancient would lower its arthritic arm. The towman waited with his baggage.

good

He wasn't cold against the dawn. He was sweating. Steam escaped from his untacked collar, his sleeve holes—vented from his back through eyelets meant for hooking lines during a manual tow. He himself was like a machine—working—locomoting—dripping from his cuffs due to

good

condensation. Pace wiggled and slipped a little. Henry drove into the ground with his hind and, using the opposing force borrowed from the earth, shrugged Pace up. The long one nestled into the hollow between the large man's neck and shoulder, slumping like a wet noodle.

The passenger lift thunked. And stopped. Henry John stepped on, and without a wasted moment, the hydraulics hissed, drawing him up. He turned slowly to face the horizon. The clouds were pregnant. The winds chanted higher and faster. The embryonic dawn showed its bump and it was all glory waiting to be born. Henry John closed his eyes and said a prayer. The morning light careened off his black skin, though lined and wrinkled, to a smoothness as if he had been molded from bronze… burnished to gold….

good

just keep playing with the contrast and it will tell you

I really like Henry John, especially contrasted with Pace's... instability. How could we use this for the story?

The lift stopped. The passenger side door slid open. Inside, the cabin was spartan like a chapel.

good

Two benchs sat side by side near the front: one for the driver, one for the navigator. Behind, terraced higher and welded to the walls, were two other benches for the robotics-wincher and gunner-planner. In the center of the cabin, cleared by an oval, sat empty the commander's chair. Panoramic windows ran around the room, providing a sweeping view of the desert floor. The Sun

benches

harder for me to visualize what is meant here

in a clear oval (?)

is it really though?

crowned. Hues of blue flooded the valley, refracting through the glass—thick as Henry John—painting the room underwater.

a little confusing

The benches were all factory-new. Though sunlight had bleached them pale over time. That is, except for the driver's seat, which sagged from holding weight day after day. Stacked with cushions rubbed frayed, backed by a poncho, it—and not the commander's chair—had the real look of command.

integrate this para with the one prior

And the story goes on to move the plot along,
currently planned is that they ride along,
chat about the world and war,
Pace's a drugged out racer looking to run a race called
the Mach 1K which is why he's going to Vegas
there's a backstory about how his dad's soul/consciousness
is trapped in the architecture of Las Vegas and Pace's
motivation is to free his dad.
Along the route they run into Splinters looking for Elvira
and Hanu the daemon (owned by Lola Dawn) shows up / and currently that's
planned as the end of the Chapter 2 and how Pace gets pulled into
Elvira and the larger plot. Also, currently, Pace in my mind
is either just "replacement for Bruce" OR he's a literal combination
of Bruce + Marcos personalities in one body.

good

thanks for reading

under the iceberg: Why was Henry John there?
On his way to doing something else, or specifically responding to Pace's crash being "called in"/radared?